

Camp offers kids a taste of the great outdoors

One formerly indoorsy camper had so much fun he's going again this year

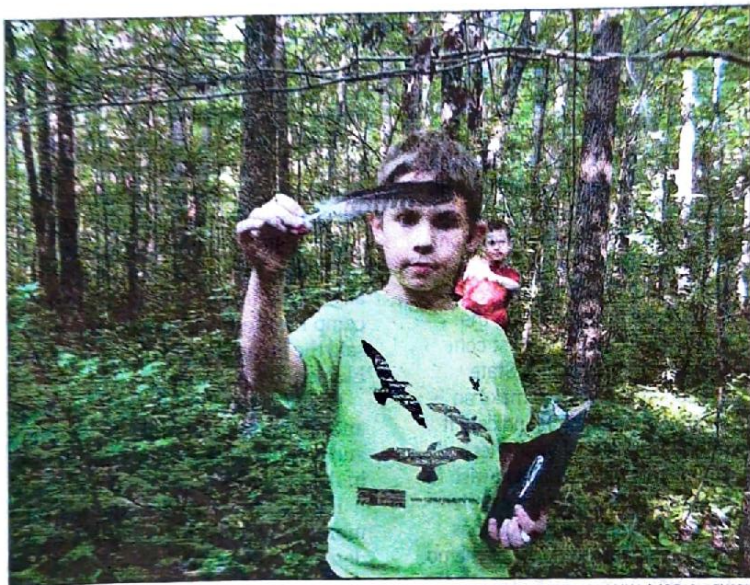
BY CRISTINA BOLLING
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Karan Barber sees it every summer. When kids file in for the first day of camp at the Carolina Raptor Center, many are dismayed to find it's a no-electronic-gadget zone.

Then comes their first foray into the wilderness around the Huntersville facility, and some are downright scared.

She remembers a day last summer

when a nearly 6-foot-tall, 13-year-old boy who attended camp through a Charlotte Observer scholarship was so afraid of walking through the woods, he asked to put his hand on



COURTESY OF THE CAROLINA RAPTOR CENTER

Tyler Floyd, 10, holds up a feather during his week at the Carolina Raptor Center's Nature Scene Investigators camp last summer.

her shoulder.

"We had taken him into a completely foreign environment. He had never been where all you could see was nature," Barber says.

But he managed.

And by the week's end, his whole philosophy on the outdoors had changed.

"Indoor kids become outdoor kids," Barber says.

The Carolina Raptor Center, a non-

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profit dedicated to rehabilitating injured and orphaned raptors as well as educating the public about environmental stewardship, hosts 24 children each week for a five-day themed camp. The day camp, which costs \$261.50 a week, is offered for six weeks during the summer for children ages 7-14.

Camp themes range from young veterinarians camp, where kids learn about the anatomy and physiology of birds at the facility's medical center, to an "NSI" camp (Nature Scene Investigators) where youngsters learn to use knowledge and curiosity to enjoy the mystery of nature.

This is the third summer the Raptor Center, founded in 1981, will host scholarship children through the Charlotte Observer's Summer Camp Fund.

The fund, in its fifth year, aims to send children from low-income families to day and overnight summer camps. This summer, 206 children from the Charlotte area will attend camp through the fund.

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